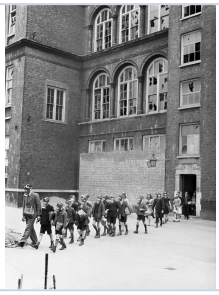
Outbreak 1939 & Home Front Mobilisation

Key Enquiry Question: Why did ordinary British families carry cardboard boxes and tape their windows in September 1939?

LESSON 01
KEY STAGE 2



Source A: *Schoolchildren in double file across the playground during a gas mask drill in 1941. (Imperial War Museum)*

HISTORICAL READING • WHAT THIS TELLS US

On Sunday 3 September 1939, Prime Minister Neville Chamberlain announced over the radio that Britain was at war with Germany. Within fifteen minutes, the first air raid siren sounded across London.

Fearing that enemy bombers might drop poison gas bombs, the government issued **38 million gas masks** in cardboard boxes with string straps. Even walking to school or playing outside, children had to carry their boxes everywhere and practise wearing them during lessons.

Task 1: Artifact Detective • The Civilian Gas Mask

PRIMARY EVIDENCE



Source B: *Authentic 1939 British civilian respirator showing the moulded black rubber facepiece, celluloid viewing visor, and cylindrical filter canister with perforated metal inlet. (Auckland War Memorial Museum AM 1995.59.20)*

1. Look closely at Source B. How did the rubber facepiece and filter canister protect ordinary civilians from poison gas, and why did the British government issue over 38 million of these masks in 1939?

2. Comparing Source A and Source B, what does having to wear these rubber respirators in school gas-mask drills tell us about how the fear of aerial bombing changed daily childhood?

Task 2: Active Chronological Challenge • The First 72 Hours of War

CHRONOLOGICAL UNDERSTANDING

STAGE 1 • 3 SEPT 1939

The Radio Announcement

Chamberlain speaks at 11:15am. Within minutes, the first wailing air raid siren sounds across Britain.

How would you and your family react to hearing that siren for the first time?

STAGE 2 • 4 SEPT 1939

The Blackout Begins

Streetlights turned off; car lights dimmed; windows covered with thick black curtains or painted.

Why was lighting even a single match outdoors strictly forbidden by Wardens?

STAGE 3 • 5 SEPT 1939

School Playground Drills

Teachers time pupils to fit rubber face masks in 10 seconds and practise doing sums in silence.

What strange sensations and sounds would children experience inside the mask?

Task 3: Visual Investigation • Gas Mask Carrier Inspection & Daily Emergency Kit

TACTILE INVESTIGATION

🎨 **Pupil Sketching Canvas: Draw your cardboard respirator box, shoulder carrying strap and official label above**

1. Cardboard Box & Shoulder Strap
Why must this box never be left behind on a bus, playground, or bedroom?

2. Eye-Piece Anti-Dimming Ointment
Why was a small cloth or soap stick stored inside to stop breath fogging the glass?

3. Sticky Window Adhesive Tape
Why did families criss-cross sticky brown tape across living room windows?

4. National Identity Card (N.I.)
Why did every civilian have to carry an identity card with their unique serial number?

Task 4: "Thinking Heads" • Contrasting Historical Perspectives

CONTRASTING PERSPECTIVES

1 10-Year-Old London Schoolchild

What fears, discomforts, or strange curiosities do you feel carrying this black rubber mask to school on your first day of war?

2 Air Raid Precautions (ARP) Warden

What serious responsibilities do you hold patrolling pitch-black streets at night shouting 'Put that light out!'?

Task 5: Mission Challenge • Preparing for Total War

HISTORIAN CHALLENGE

Big Question: In what ways did the outbreak of war and the fear of aerial bombing transform the daily routine of ordinary British schoolchildren within just 72 hours?

✂ **Hands-On Primary Artefact Activity:** Complete your official Air Raid Warden identification card, cut out your authentic Blackout Door Hanger, and label your civilian gas mask inspection tag.

✂ CUT OUT WARDEN CARD

AIR RAID PRECAUTIONS — HOME SECURITY ACT 1939

CIVIL DEFENCE SERVICE • WARDEN WARRANT

PASTE PHOTO OR DRAW WARDEN PORTRAIT

WARDEN NAME: _____

POST DISTRICT: Sector Post 14 • Ward B

WARRANT NO: ARP-1939-LONDON-584

DATE APPOINTED: 3 September 1939

"The appointed Warden is empowered by His Majesty's Government to patrol streets, direct civilians to air raid shelters, report bomb damage, and enforce total blackout extinction of all light."

Warden Signature: _____

Valid for duration of Civil Defence emergency.

OFFICIAL ARP WARDEN SEAL

✂ CUT OUT & PUNCH HOLE

(Punch hole for string loop)

CIVILIAN RESPIRATOR NO. 2894

PUPIL NAME: _____

SCHOOL / CLASS: _____

RESPIRATOR SIZE: [ ] Small (Child) [ ] Medium [ ] Mickey Mouse Mask

GAS DRILL RECORD: Wk 1: [✓] Wk 2: [✓] Wk 3: [✓] Wk 4: [✓] **PASSED DRILL**

✂ CUT DOOR HANGER ✂

CUT OUT CIRCLE FOR DOOR KNOB

MINISTRY OF HOME SECURITY • AIR RAID PRECAUTIONS

PUT THAT LIGHT OUT!

WARNING: BY ORDER OF THE AIR RAID WARDEN

Between the hours of sunset and sunrise, NO LIGHT of any description must be visible from the exterior of this building. Enemy bomber aircraft use illuminated windows as navigational beacons.

MANDATORY HOME FRONT REGULATIONS:

- Ensure black cloth curtains or dark blankets are pinned firmly to window frames.
- Ensure adhesive sticky tape is affixed in diagonal crosses to all glass panes.
- Do not strike matches or shine electric torches outdoors during raid warnings.

STRICT PENALTY: Any breach of blackout regulations will result in immediate police summons and a fine of up to £50 or 1 month imprisonment.

Patrolling Warden: _____

Sector Post: **No. 14 East** • Date: **Sept 1939**

PASSED WARDEN INSPECTION